Amtorg, during the war, Knox was on a business trip to the USSR when he was summoned to see Khrushchev at an hour's notice. *Pravda* reported that the meeting took place at Knox's request. It lasted three hours. The Soviet leader went on the offensive, stating that Kennedy's announcement of October 22 was the result of his inexperience, electoral pressures, and outright hysteria. Kennedy was a young man, said Khrushchev, younger than Khrushchev's own son, and he could not imagine Eisenhower acting in such a manner.[7]

Khrushchev rejected Knox's suggestion that he had deceived Kennedy, but then made the most striking statement of the entire meeting, admitting that he had deployed not just ballistic missiles but also nuclear warheads in Cuba. "The Soviet Union had antiaircraft missiles in Cuba, as well as ballistic missiles with both conventional and nuclear warheads," reads the State Department summary of Knox's conversation with Khrushchev. The missiles were 100 percent under Soviet control and could be fired only in defense of Cuba and only on his personal orders, continued Khrushchev. If the Americans did not believe him, they could try to attack Cuba, and Guantánamo would be wiped out the first day of the conflict. According to another account, Khrushchev told Knox that he did not want war, but if the United States decided to start one, he was ready. "We'll all meet in hell," he told the surprised businessman.

But it was not all attacks and threats. Khrushchev wanted Knox to know that he was prepared to meet with Kennedy in the United States, the Soviet Union, at sea, or anywhere else. He remarked that the conflict was untimely, since Gromyko and Rusk had reached an understanding on a nuclear test ban and European frontiers. He then told Knox a joke about a man who did not like the smell of his goat but eventually learned to live with it. The Soviet Union had its goats in Italy and Greece and had learned to live with them. The United States was getting its goat in Cuba. The message to Kennedy was clear: I did indeed place nuclear missiles in Cuba, as you did on my borders. Get used to it.[8]

On the same day Khrushchev responded to Kennedy's letter of the previous day requesting him to turn Soviet ships back from the quarantine line. Early that morning, he had received the good news that the *Aleksandrovsk*, with nuclear warheads on board, had successfully reached